



All you need to know about catching viruses and keeping your PC bug free

Virusproof forever

ignorance \Ig"no*rance\, n. [F., fr. L. ignorantia.] 1. The condition of being ignorant; the want of knowledge in general, or in relation to a particular subject; the state of being uneducated or uninformed.

(Source: Webster's Revised Unabridged Dictionary, © 1996, 1998 MICRA, Inc.)

Why on earth would an anti-virus tool become the world's second most widely used class of software after an operating system? Why is it that more than 10 per cent of the data losses worldwide occur because of only a hundred lines of code? Why are networks that were supposed to help us communicate with each other now turning into 'virus streams' and infection mediums? Why is it that the word 'Nimda' is a more familiar word than 'Linux' in a not-so-actively-computing-lifeform's dictionary? Why has the media started giving so much attention to all the virus attacks nowadays?

This is just a short list of whys that we want answered, but since we not-so-powerful beings are not capable of mass communication and mind control, we opted for introspection. All we found during that introspection was the word this article starts off with—ignorance!

Yes! Believe us, that's the answer to all those

whys. That is the cause of losses amounting to millions of dollars due to data/network usage loss, or even those wasted CPU cycles on your PC that you think don't count for any money. No virus, no Trojan, no worm, no matter how powerful, can get to you if you know how they work and squish them right at the entry point. Or even better, never let the entry point be insecure.

Now it's time to see how these intelligently designed but extremely malicious pieces of code work.

The virus

In a lay person's language, a computer virus would be best described as a small program that is specifically written to subvert the normal operations of a computer, thereby making it malfunction. Worms use exploits or loopholes in operating systems or other programs (e-mail clients and Internet browsers, for instance) to propagate or harm systems. Worms are quite similar to viruses when it comes to spreading, except that they're a lot more intelligent and sophisticated. Depending on how a worm is